UNITED NATIONS AND PEACEKEEPING

United Nations peacekeeping is a unique and dynamic instrument developed by the Organization as a way to help countries torn by conflict and create the conditions for lasting peace. The first UN peacekeeping mission was established in 1948, when the Security Council authorized the deployment of UN military observers to the Middle East to monitor the Armistice Agreement between Israel and its Arab neighbours. Since then, there have been a total of 63 UN peacekeeping operations around the world. At present 15 Peace Keeping Operations are going on along with 17 peace operations under the direction and support of the Department of Peace Keeping Operations.

The term ‘peacekeeping’ is not found in the United Nations Charter and is difficult to find a simple definition. Dag Hammarskjöld, the second UN Secretary-General, referred to it as belonging to “Chapter Six and a Half” of the Charter, placing it between traditional methods of resolving disputes peacefully, such as negotiation and mediation under Chapter VI, and more forceful action as authorized under Chapter VII.

Peacekeeping is the deployment of a United Nations presence in the field, hitherto with the consent of all the parties concerned, normally involving United Nations military and/or police personnel and frequently civilians as well. It is a technique that expands the possibilities for both the prevention of conflict and the making of peace.

All members of the United Nations share the costs of UNPK operations. The General Assembly apportions the expense for meeting the expenses based on a special scale of assessment applicable to UNPK. The scale often taken into account, is the relative economic wealth of the member state. The permanent members of the Security Council are required to pay a larger share because of their special responsibility for maintenance of international peace and security. As of January, 2008, the top 10 contributors have been the United States, Japan, Germany, the United Kingdom, France, Italy, China, Canada, Spain and the